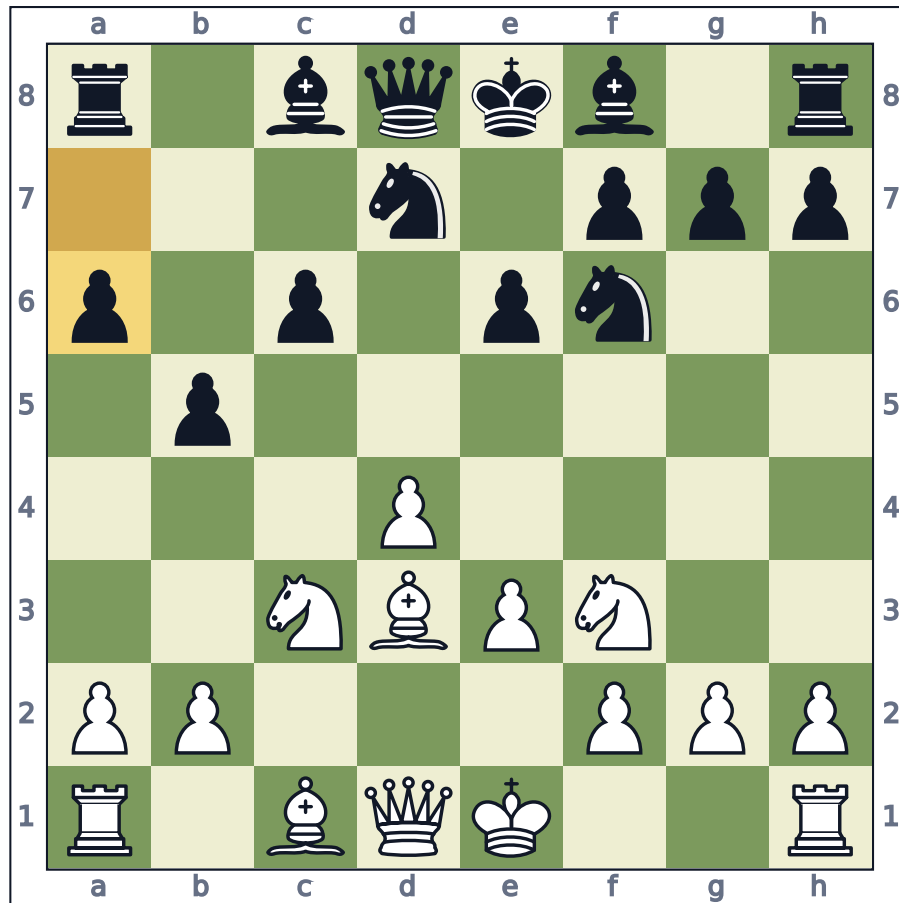


Semi-Slav Defense

A ground-up visual course for practical play



Core route position - gold marks the last move

BOTH SIDES

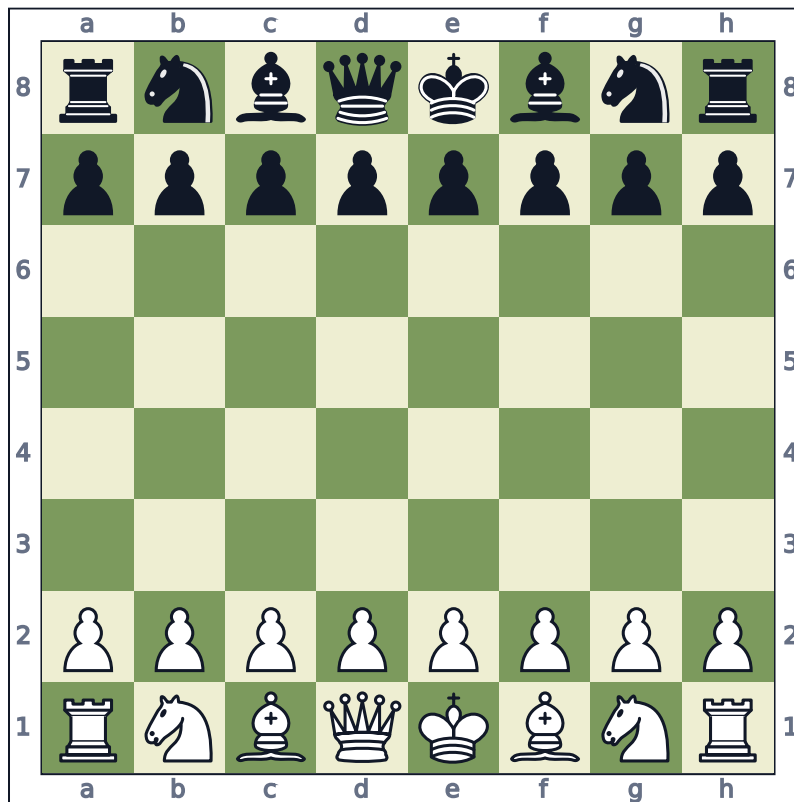
OPENING IDENTITY

Black combines Slav solidity with ...e6, creating a compact but very dynamic structure.

ORIENTATION

Ground zero: read the board and the moves

White starts from ranks 1-2; Black starts from ranks 7-8. Files run a through h. Each lesson highlights the last move in gold so your eyes connect notation to the board.



Starting position - White to move

HOW ALGEBRAIC NOTATION WORKS

Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. B means bishop, R rook, Q queen, K king; pawns use only the destination square. An x means capture, + means check, and O-O means kingside castling.

YOUR FIRST ANCHOR

Say the first moves aloud, then point to every destination square:

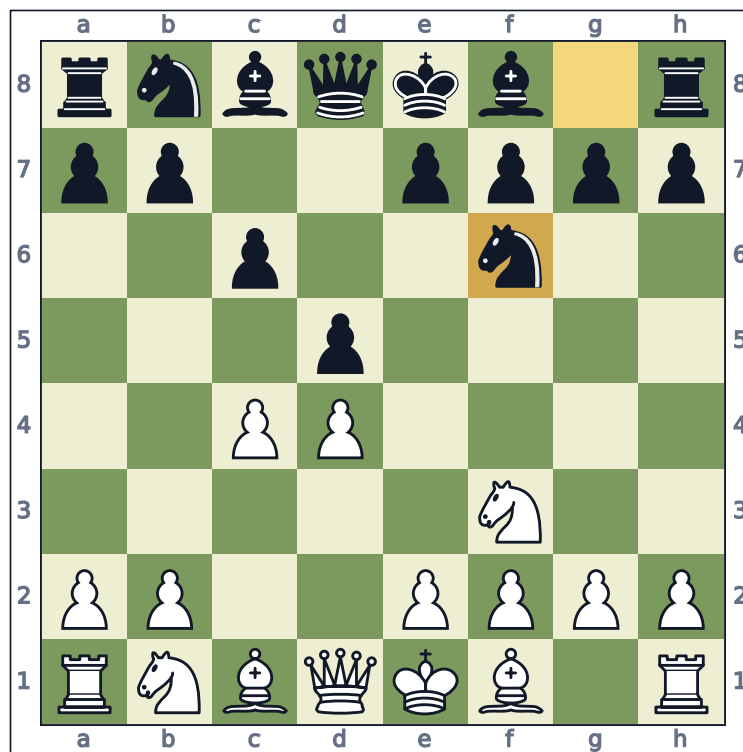
1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6

Course promise: Compact shell, then a timed central explosion.

MOVES 1-3

Lesson 1: the first conversation

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6



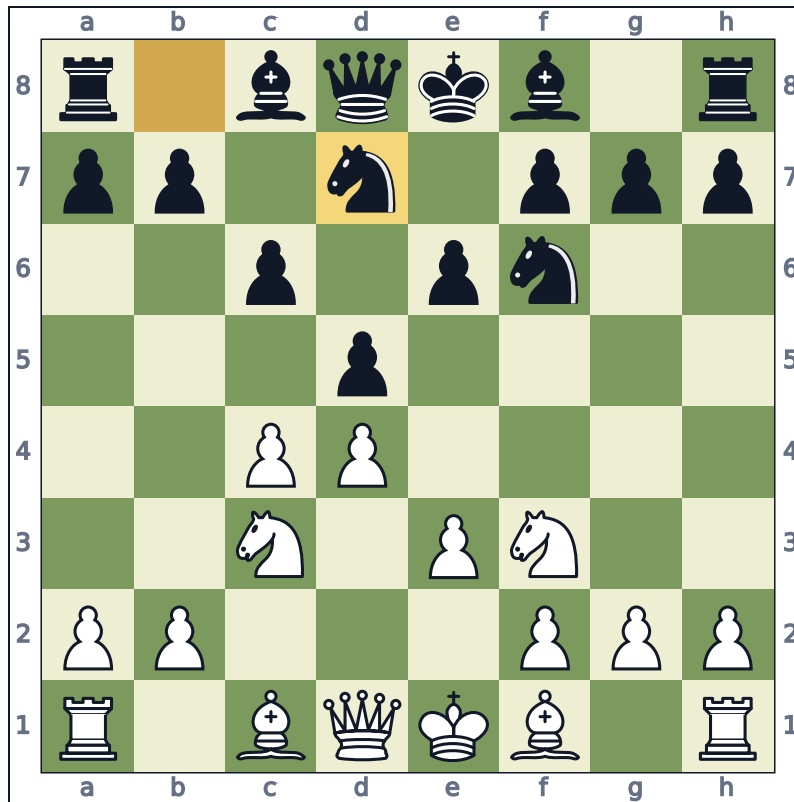
After 3. Nf3 Nf6

- 1. d4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 1... d5 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 2. c4 - Creates a lever against the center or supports a coming break.
- 2... c6 - Creates a lever against the center or supports a coming break.
- 3. Nf3 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.
- 3... Nf6 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.

DEVELOPMENT

Lesson 2: build the core position

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7



WHAT THE PIECES ARE BUILDING

Black combines Slav solidity with ...e6, creating a compact but very dynamic structure.

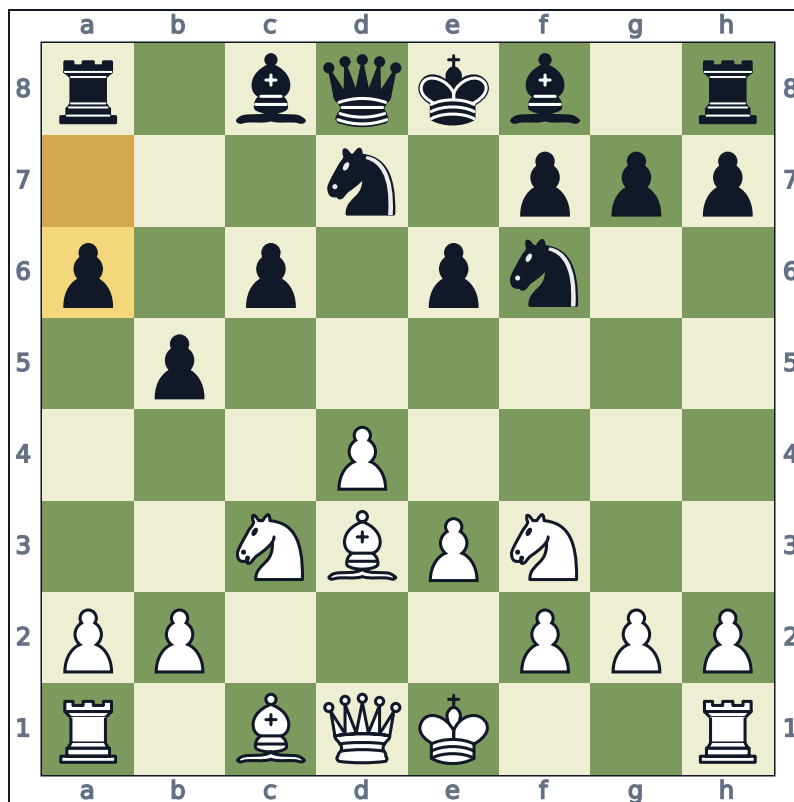
BEGINNER CHECKPOINT

Before copying the next move, ask: Is my king safe? Which piece is still at home? What changed in the center? Which pawn break is each side preparing?

CORE LINE

Lesson 3: complete the main route

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6



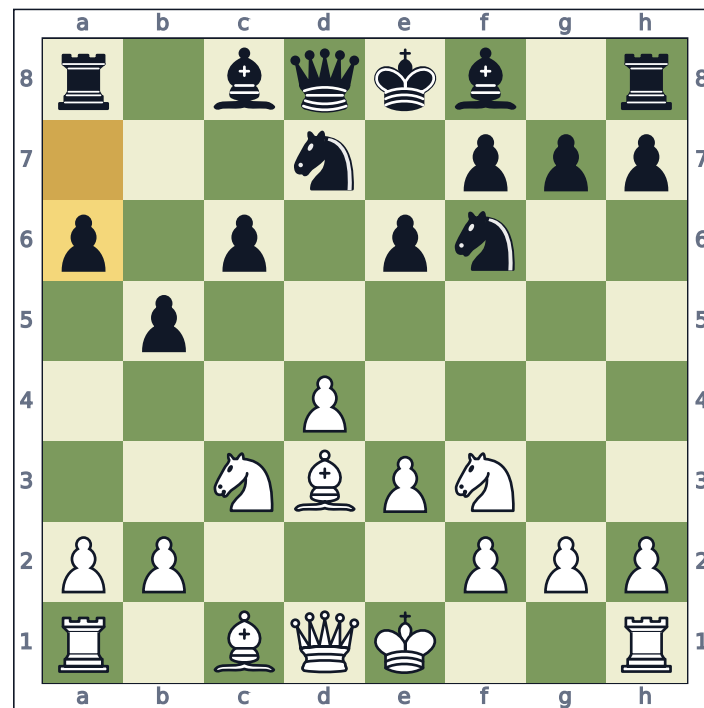
Core position - now plans matter more than memorized moves

DO NOT MEMORIZE BLINDLY

The route is a model, not a forced script. Its job is to teach this relationship: Black combines Slav solidity with ...e6, creating a compact but very dynamic structure. If the opponent deviates, preserve the same priorities until a concrete tactic changes them.

UNDERSTANDING

The position map: plans for both sides



Read plans from the pawn structure, not from the opening name

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop quickly, use e4 when possible, and exploit the time Black spends on queenside expansion.

BLACK'S PLAN

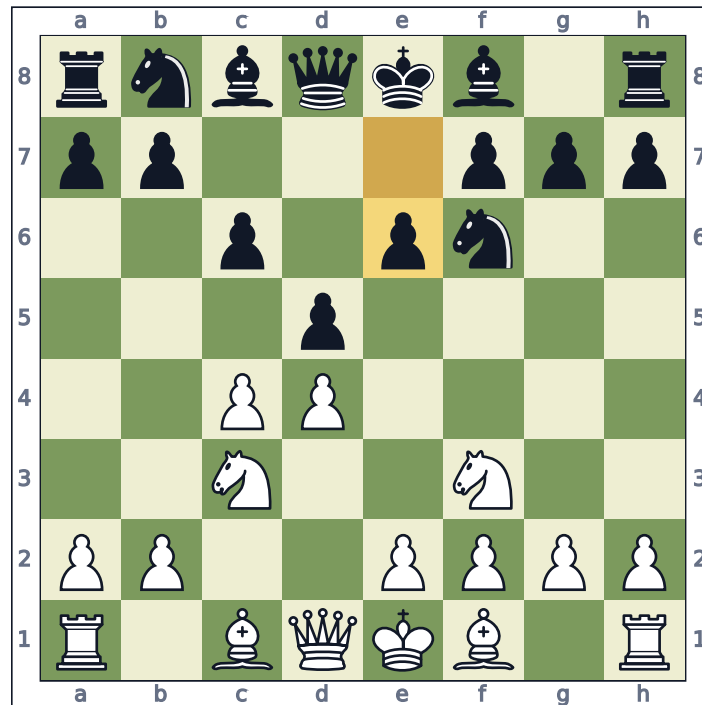
Support the center, gain time with ...b5, and prepare ...c5 or ...e5.

THE LEVER TO REMEMBER

...c5 and ...e5 are the central liberating breaks.

CALCULATION

Tactical literacy: what can suddenly change



Pause here - White to move

THEME

The c4 capture can invite e4-e5 tactics if Black's king and center lag behind.

COMMON BEGINNER ERROR

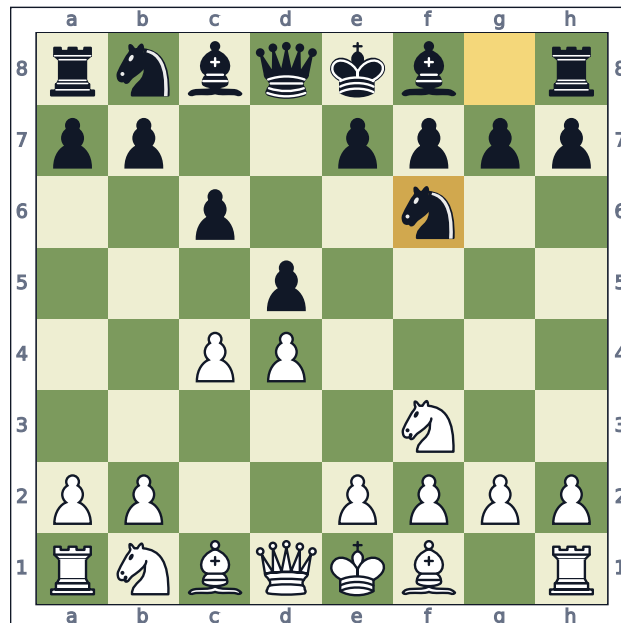
Memorizing sharp branches before understanding why Black takes on c4.

THREE-SECOND SAFETY SCAN

1. Checks against both kings. 2. Captures in the center. 3. Threats against loose or pinned pieces.

ADAPTATION

Decision tree: when the opponent leaves the route



A branch point - principles are your map

1. If the center stays fluid

Finish development and keep the opening identity in view: Black combines Slav solidity with ...e6, creating a compact but very dynamic structure.

2. If the center closes

Use the pawn-chain direction. Attack the base before making wing moves that cannot be supported.

3. If the center opens

Prioritize king safety, active pieces, and checks or captures before slow pawn moves.

4. If nothing is forced

Return to the planned lever: ...c5 and ...e5 are the central liberating breaks.

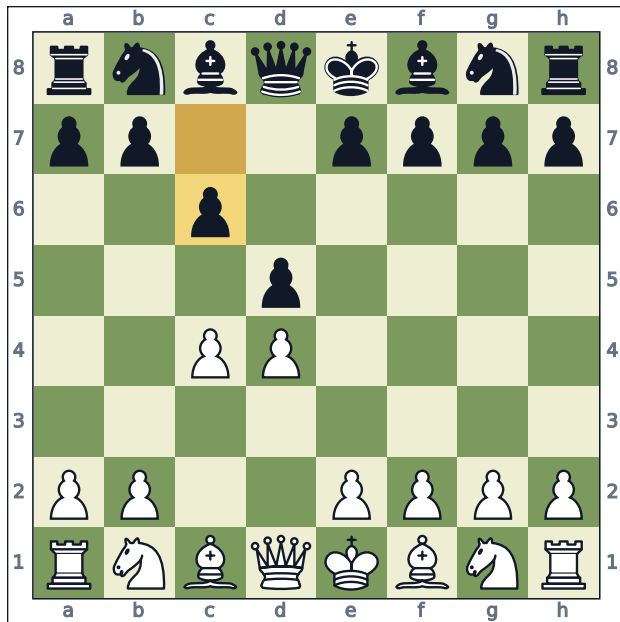
MEMORY SENTENCE

Compact shell, then a timed central explosion.

ACTIVE RECALL

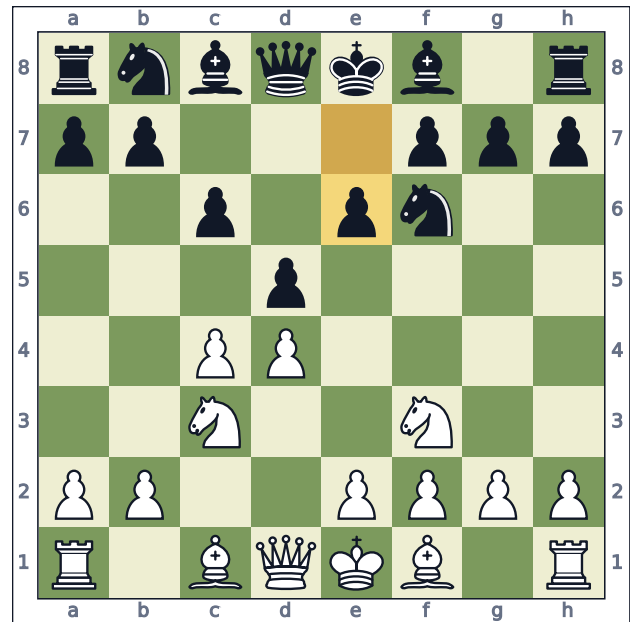
Recall test: answer before you turn the page

POSITION A



White to move

POSITION B



White to move

- A1. What is the next route move for White?
- A2. What opening problem does that move solve?
- B1. What is the next route move for White?
- B2. Name one plan for White and one plan for Black.
- C. State the thematic pawn break without looking back.

SCORING

5/5: replay from memory. 3-4/5: review Lessons 3 and 6. 0-2/5: return to Lesson 1 and rebuild the route slowly.

RETENTION

Answer key and a 14-day practice loop

POSITION A

Next route move: Nf3. Explain it using development, center, king safety, or a direct tactical need.

POSITION B

Next route move: e3. Then compare the position with the final core board.

PLAN AND BREAK ANSWERS

White: Develop quickly, use e4 when possible, and exploit the time Black spends on queenside expansion. Black: Support the center, gain time with ...b5, and prepare ...c5 or ...e5. Lever: ...c5 and ...e5 are the central liberating breaks.

14-DAY LOOP

- Days 1-2: replay the first three moves from both sides and name each move's job.
- Days 3-4: build the core position from memory; correct the first error, then restart.
- Days 5-6: say White's plan, Black's plan, and the pawn break without a board.
- Day 7: take the recall test. Record the score; do not count lucky guesses.
- Days 8-10: play three slow practice games, starting from the core position if possible.
- Days 11-13: review only mistakes and deviations that actually occurred in your games.
- Day 14: retake the test and write a one-sentence opening rule in your own words.